FREE FINANCING REPORT

Marina Financing Report

Why This Category Is a Genuine Growth Story With a Narrow Lending Channel, What the 2026 Environment Looks Like, and the Metrics That Drive Approvals

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Why Marina Financing Requires a Different Approach

Marinas sit at the intersection of waterfront real estate and hospitality-style operations, and 2026 data shows a category with genuinely strong fundamentals served by a narrow but active specialized lending channel. That combination — double-digit revenue growth, historically high occupancy, and a dedicated SBA and specialty-lender financing pathway — is exactly why marina financing remains accessible for well-prepared operators, even though most conventional lenders stay away from the category entirely.

- **A genuine specialized financing pathway exists.** SBA 504 loans currently price at a fixed 6.03% while SBA 7(a) loans run at a variable 6.75% (as of August 2026), with leverage up to 90% LTV (and up to 100% possible in some cases) and amortizations extending up to 25 years.
- **Revenue growth is running well ahead of broader commercial real estate.** Marinas reported 14% median year-over-year revenue growth in 2026, reflecting continued strength in boating demand and improving rate management.
- **Occupancy remains historically strong across much of the industry.** More than half of surveyed marinas report occupancy in the 95% to 100% range, with roughly 58% experiencing year-over-year occupancy gains.
- **Structural barriers to entry protect existing operators.** Roughly 11,500 marinas operate nationwide, generating an estimated $18 billion in economic impact, with environmental and permitting restrictions making new competitive supply difficult to add.
- **Approval timelines can move quickly with the right specialty lender.** Some marina-focused lenders offer written pre-approvals within 48 hours and charge no upfront application or processing fees.

That said, this remains a narrow, specialized lending channel. Most conventional commercial lenders avoid marinas altogether given the operational complexity, seasonality, and environmental exposure involved. Specialty marina lenders also generally require a minimum loan amount around $1.5 million, positioning this financing pathway toward established or larger facilities. Lenders scrutinize dock and infrastructure condition, environmental and permitting status, and operator experience closely — well-documented, stabilized marinas with experienced operators continue to finance far more easily than facilities with deferred maintenance or unresolved permitting questions.

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2026 Market Outlook for Marina Financing

Marina financing enters 2026 backed by genuinely strong underlying fundamentals, even as the pool of active lenders remains narrow and specialized. The following figures outline where the market stands:

- Specialized SBA and bank financing anchors the category: SBA 504 loans currently price at a fixed 6.03% while SBA 7(a) loans run at a variable 6.75% (as of August 2026), with leverage up to 90% LTV (and up to 100% possible in some cases) and amortizations extending up to 25 years.

  Source: SelectCommercial, Marina Loan Program, 2026

- Minimum loan sizes reflect the specialized, larger-scale nature of marina transactions: specialty marina lenders generally require a minimum loan amount of $1.5 million, positioning this financing pathway toward established or larger facilities rather than very small operations.

  Source: SelectCommercial, 2026

- Revenue growth is running well ahead of broader commercial real estate: marinas reported 14% median year-over-year revenue growth in 2026, reflecting continued strength in boating demand and improving rate management.

  Source: Storable Marine, Marina Industry Trends 2026

- Consumer booking behavior is shifting toward digital, which lenders increasingly view as a sign of professionalized operations: 71% of boaters want to book online, 55% expect digital check-in, and 56% of bookings now occur within one week of departure.

  Source: Storable Marine, 2026

- Occupancy remains historically strong across much of the industry: more than half of surveyed marinas report occupancy in the 95% to 100% range, with roughly 58% of respondents experiencing year-over-year occupancy gains, led by the Midwest and South.

  Source: Leisure Investment Properties Group, Marinas: Supply & Demand Factors

- Supply remains structurally constrained: roughly 11,500 marinas operate nationwide generating an estimated $18 billion in economic impact, with high barriers to entry from environmental and permitting restrictions limiting new competitive supply.

  Source: Leisure Investment Properties Group

Bottom line for 2026: Marina financing sits on genuinely strong footing — double-digit revenue growth, historically high occupancy, and structurally limited new supply all favor well-run operators. But the lending channel remains narrow: most conventional lenders avoid the category, specialty lenders generally require loans of $1.5 million or more, and approval still hinges on clean dock, environmental, and permitting documentation as much as on the underlying market strength.

Sources: SelectCommercial, Marina Loan Program, 2026; Storable Marine, Marina Industry Trends 2026; Leisure Investment Properties Group, Marinas: Supply & Demand Factors

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Critical Financing Metrics for Marinas

Lenders in this space underwrite the operating business as closely as the waterfront real estate itself. The following metrics most often determine whether a request moves forward:

1. **Slip Occupancy Rate**

   Trailing occupancy across wet slips, dry storage, and transient business, since occupancy strength is the clearest signal of demand and cash-flow durability.

   95%–100% occupancy reported at more than half of surveyed marinas

2. **Slip Mix and Revenue Diversification**

   The balance of wet slips, dry stack storage, transient traffic, and ancillary income (fuel, store, service, restaurant), which supports revenue stability across seasons.

3. **Dock and Infrastructure Condition**

   Condition of docks, utilities, and upland facilities, since deferred maintenance is one of the fastest ways to lose lender confidence on waterfront assets.

4. **Environmental and Permitting Status**

   Documentation confirming clean environmental condition and resolved permitting, given the regulatory exposure inherent to waterfront property.

5. **Operator Experience in Marina or Marine Operations**

   Documented management track record, given the operational complexity of running a seasonal, multi-revenue-stream waterfront facility.

6. **Loan-to-Value**

   Leverage available through SBA and specialized marina lender channels.

   up to 90% LTV (up to 100% in select cases)

7. **Loan Program and Term**

   Rate and amortization structure available depending on program selection.

   SBA 504 fixed ~6.03%; SBA 7(a) variable ~6.75%; terms up to 25 years

These metrics form the practical filter that separates marina financing requests that get funded from those that stall in underwriting.

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Practical Framework & Getting It Right the First Time

Pre-Submission Checklist

Before approaching lenders, confirm:

- [ ] Trailing 12-month operating statements are organized
- [ ] Slip occupancy and revenue history (by slip type and stay length) is documented
- [ ] Slip count, mix (wet/dry/transient), dock, utility, and upland facility details are prepared
- [ ] Environmental and permitting documentation is complete
- [ ] Operator experience in marinas or marine-related businesses is clearly presented
- [ ] Market and competitive context (local boating demand, nearby facilities) is gathered
- [ ] Existing debt schedule and entity documents are current
- [ ] Personal financial statements and credit information for owners/guarantors are up to date

Common Reasons Marina Financing Requests Underperform or Get Declined

- Missing or incomplete occupancy and revenue history
- Weak or outdated dock and infrastructure documentation
- Unresolved environmental or permitting issues
- Insufficient operator experience in marina or marine operations
- A loan request below typical specialty lender minimums without an alternative financing plan

Final Perspective

Marina financing in 2026 rests on genuinely strong fundamentals — double-digit revenue growth, historically high occupancy, and structural barriers that limit new competitive supply. But because most conventional lenders avoid the category and specialty lenders generally require larger loan sizes, the deals that finance most smoothly are the ones where the operator has proactively documented occupancy strength, infrastructure condition, and a clean environmental and permitting record.

High-level knowledge of how these loans work is valuable. Turning that knowledge into a funded transaction still requires the right preparation and the right lending relationships.

Getting it right the first time matters. Missing occupancy history, weak infrastructure or environmental documentation, and unresolved permitting questions are among the most common reasons otherwise solid marina financing requests lose time, money, and momentum.

YOUR NEXT STEP

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